

# Imputed Righteousness

doc-imputed-righteousness

Soteriology · Justification · doctrine · unanimous\_lineages

## AFFIRMS

score 0.932  
confidence high

### Statement under examination

In justification, the believer is reckoned righteous before God on the basis of Christ's work received by faith, not on the basis of righteousness inherent in the believer.

### In plain language

The proposition asks whether God reckons a person righteous in justification on the basis of Christ's work received by faith, rather than on the basis of righteousness already inside the person. The key Greek verb is 'to count or reckon' (logizomai), an accounting word that the lexicon defines as to count or reckon, to take into account. It appears across thirty nine verses, eleven of them in Romans 4 alone. In that chapter Paul even uses it commercially in verse 4, where a worker's pay is reckoned to his account, which fixes the sense as crediting rather than producing. He quotes Genesis 15:6 twice, in Romans 4 and Galatians 3, where God counts Abraham's faith as righteousness, the Hebrew verb there being 'to count or reckon' (chashav), which likewise means to count or reckon. The decisive line is Romans 4:5: God justifies the ungodly, 'the ungodly one' (asebes), the one who is not working but believing. If the person being justified is at that moment ungodly, the righteousness credited cannot already be a quality inside him. Romans 4:6 adds apart from works, and Romans 4:8 shows the same accounting can withhold the charge of sin. 2 Corinthians 5:21 says we become God's righteousness in him, placing the righteousness in Christ, and Philippians 3:9 contrasts my own righteousness from law with the righteousness from God by faith. The Old Testament agrees: Jeremiah 23:6 names the Branch the Lord our righteousness, binding the people's righteousness to another, and Isaiah 53:11 says the Servant justifies many while bearing their guilt. So the words clearly say the righteousness is reckoned, not generated from the believer. Where readers diverge is the next question the words leave open: what exactly is the reckoned thing, Christ's own obedience credited, the faith itself counted, a shared righteousness by union, or a righteousness later worked in. The verb settles the accounting but not its content, and the verb 'to constitute or appoint' (kathistemi) in Romans 5:19 usually means to install in an office, which is the seam a transformation reading uses.

### Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

| Strong | Word     | Sounds like | Plain meaning | Times in Bible |
|--------|----------|-------------|---------------|----------------|
| H0539  | אָמֵן    | aman        | be faithful   |                |
| H0835  | אֶשֶׁר   | esher       | blessed       |                |
| H2803  | חָשַׁב   | chashav     | to devise     | 124            |
| H3068  | יְהוָה   | YHWH        | LORD          | 6,828          |
| H5445  | יָסַבֵּל | saval       | to bear       |                |
| H6588  | פָּשַׁע  | pesah       | transgression |                |
| H6663  | צָדִיק   | tsadaq      | to justify    | 41             |
| H6664  | צֶדֶק    | tsedeq      | righteousness | 119            |

|              |            |            |                    |     |
|--------------|------------|------------|--------------------|-----|
| <b>H6666</b> | יִצְדָּקָה | tsedaqah   | righteousness      | 157 |
| <b>G0011</b> | Ἀβραάμ     | Abraam     | Abraham            | 73  |
| <b>G0266</b> | ἁμαρτίαν   | hamartia   | sin                |     |
| <b>G0268</b> | ἁμαρτωλοὶ  | hamartōlos | sinful             |     |
| <b>G0765</b> | ἀσεβής     | asebes     | ungodly            | 9   |
| <b>G1342</b> | δίκαιος    | dikaios    | just               | 76  |
| <b>G1343</b> | δικαιοσύνη | dikaiosune | righteousness      | 87  |
| <b>G1344</b> | δικαιόω    | dikaioo    | to justify         | 35  |
| <b>G2038</b> | ἐργαζομένω | ergazomai  | to work            |     |
| <b>G2041</b> | ἔργον      | ergon      | work               | 177 |
| <b>G2316</b> | θεοῦ       | theos      | God                |     |
| <b>G2525</b> | καθίστημι  | kathistemi | to appoint/conduct | 21  |
| <b>G3049</b> | λογίζομαι  | logizomai  | to count           | 39  |
| <b>G3107</b> | μακάριος   | makarios   | blessed            | 50  |
| <b>G4100</b> | πιστεύω    | pisteuo    | to trust (in)      | 251 |

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

## Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The load bearing verb is 'to count or reckon' (λογίζομαι, logizomai) (G3049), an accounting term glossed in the lexicon as to count, reckon, take into account, and used by Paul across 39 verses in the canon, eleven of them in Romans 4 alone (verses 3, 4, 5, 6, 8, 9, 10, 11, 22, 23, 24, confirmed by direct query). Paul quotes Genesis 15:6 (the Hebrew 'to count or reckon' (בַּשָּׂה, chashav), the same calculate or reckon verb, rendered 'it was counted' (ἐλογίσθη, elogisthe) in the Greek Old Testament, the Septuagint, abbreviated LXX) twice, in Romans 4:3 and Galatians 3:6, and Psalm 32:1 in Romans 4:7 to 4:8, grounding the pattern in two Old Testament witnesses. Romans 4:5 pairs the verb with 'the ungodly' (τὸν ἀσεβῆ, ton asebe) and Romans 4:6 adds 'apart from works' (χωρὶς ἔργων, choris ergon), so the righteousness reckoned at that moment is a status distinct from the person's inherent state. 2 Corinthians 5:21 ('we might become righteousness of God in him', γενώμεθα δικαιοσύνη θεοῦ ἐν αὐτῷ, genometha dikaiosune theou en auto) locates the righteousness 'in him' (ἐν αὐτῷ, en auto), that is, in Christ, and Philippians 3:9 opposes 'my own righteousness from law' (ἐμὴν δικαιοσύνην ἐκ νόμου, emen dikaiosunen ek nomou) to 'the righteousness from God' (τὴν ἐκ θεοῦ δικαιοσύνην, ten ek theou dikaiosunen). The verb says the righteousness is reckoned, not produced, so the proposition stands. The text fixes the accounting mechanism but leaves the precise content and source of the reckoned righteousness underdetermined, which is where readers diverge.

## Scripture

### Rom.4.3 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4100 ἐπίστευσεν, G3049 ἐλογίσθη, G1343 δικαιοσύνην, G0011 Ἀβραάμ

Force. Paul quotes Genesis 15:6 from the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint, LXX) word for word, 'it was counted to him for righteousness' (ἐλογίσθη αὐτῷ εἰς δικαιοσύνην, elogisthe auto eis dikaiosunen). The 'completed past action in the passive voice' (aorist passive) form 'it was counted' (ἐλογίσθη, elogisthe) with the preposition 'into' or 'for' (εἰς, eis) names a divine act of reckoning into someone's account. Faith on Abraham's side is the occasion, and righteousness is what is placed to his account. The lexicon (Abbott-Smith) classes this 'into' or 'for' (εἰς, eis) construction under to reckon, take into account, mirroring the Hebrew preposition 'to' or 'for' (ל, le) with 'to count or reckon' (כָּשַׁח, chashav).

### Rom.4.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2038 ἐργαζομένῳ, G3049 λογίζεται

Force. Paul sets the wage paradigm ('according to debt', κατὰ ὀφείλημα, kata opheilema) against the 'grace' (χάρις, charis) paradigm. To the one working, the pay is not reckoned ('it is reckoned', λογίζεται, logizetai) as grace but as obligation. The same accounting verb is used in a clearly commercial sense here, which fixes its sense as crediting to an account rather than producing a quality.

### Rom.4.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3049 λογίζεται, G1343 δικαιοσύνην, G4100 πιστεύοντι, G0765 ἀσεβῆ, G1344 δικαιούντα

Force. The decisive verse. To the one not working but believing on the one who justifies ('the one justifying', δικαιούντα, dikaiounta) the ungodly ('the ungodly one', ἀσεβῆ, asebe), his faith is reckoned ('it is reckoned', λογίζεται, logizetai) for righteousness. The object of the justifying verb is explicitly the ungodly, the 'ungodly person' (ἀσεβής, asebes), a word the lexicon glosses ungodly, impious. If the person justified is at that moment ungodly, the righteousness reckoned cannot be a quality already inherent in him.

### Rom.4.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3049 λογίζεται, G1343 δικαιοσύνην, G2041 ἔργων

Force. David pronounces blessing on the person to whom God reckons righteousness apart from works ('apart from works', χωρὶς ἔργων, choris ergon). The 'apart from' (χωρὶς, choris) construction excludes the believer's own deeds as the basis of the reckoning. The verb 'it is reckoned' (λογίζεται, logizetai) keeps its accounting sense and the subject is 'God' (ὁ θεός, ho theos), God credits.

### Rom.4.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3107 μακάριος, G3049 λογίσθη, G0266 ἁμαρτίαν

Force. Quoting Psalm 32:2 from the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint, LXX), blessed is the man whose sin the Lord will not reckon (a strong double negative 'shall in no way reckon', οὐ μὴ λογίσθη, ou me logisetai). The negative use shows 'to count or reckon' (λογίζομαι, logizomai) is an act of accounting that God can apply or withhold independent of the person's own state. Non reckoning of sin and reckoning of righteousness are the two sides of the same forensic ('courtroom-style') operation.

### Gal.3.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4100 ἐπίστευσεν, G3049 ἐλογίσθη, G1343 δικαιοσύνην

Force. Paul quotes Genesis 15:6 a second time, 'it was counted to him for righteousness' (ἐλογίσθη αὐτῷ εἰς δικαιοσύνην, elogisthe auto eis dikaiosunen), in a separate letter and argument. The independent reuse of the same reckoning formula in Galatians as in Romans shows the pattern is not a single contextual flourish but a settled lexical reading of Genesis across the Pauline corpus.

### Rom.3.28 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3049 λογιζόμεθα, G1344 δικαιούσθαι, G2041 ἔργων

Force. Paul binds the three terms together, 'for we reckon a person is justified by faith apart from works of law' (λογιζόμεθα γὰρ δικαιούσθαι πίστει ἄνθρωπον χωρὶς ἔργων νόμου, logizometha gar dikaiousthai pistei anthropon choris ergon nomou). A person is justified ('to be justified', δικαιούσθαι, dikaiousthai) by faith apart from works of law. The justifying verb and the apart from works qualifier appear in one clause, confirming the basis of the verdict is not the person's performance.

### Rom.5.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2525 κατεστάθησαν, G2525 κατασταθήσονται, G0268 ἁμαρτωλοί, G1342 δίκαιοι

Force. Parallel passive constructions. Through the disobedience of the one, the many 'were constituted' or appointed (κατεστάθησαν, katestathesan) sinners. Through the obedience of the one, the many 'will be constituted' or appointed (κατασταθήσονται, katastathesontai) righteous. The verb 'to constitute or appoint' (καθίστημι, kathistemi) is glossed in the lexicon as to set in order, appoint, make, constitute, and elsewhere in the canon it appoints to office (Matthew 24:45, Luke 12:42, Acts 6:3, Hebrews 5:1). Here the passive plus federal one to many structure denotes status assignment by representation, but the verb itself does not specify whether the constituting is purely declarative ('a verdict pronounced') or also transformative ('actually changing the person'), which is the lexical seam readers exploit.

### 2Cor.5.21 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0266 ἁμαρτίαν, G1343 δικαιοσύνη, G2316 θεοῦ

Force. The exchange clause. The one not knowing sin ('not having known sin', μὴ γνόντα ἁμαρτίαν, me gnonta hamartian) God made sin on our behalf, so that we might become God's righteousness in him ('we might become righteousness of God in him', γενώμεθα δικαιοσύνη θεοῦ ἐν αὐτῷ, genometha dikaiosune theou en auto). The verb is 'become' (γίνομαι, ginomai), become, and the 'in-location' phrase 'in him' (ἐν αὐτῷ, en auto) places the righteousness in Christ. The clause says we become this righteousness in him, which the words leave open between a credited status held in Christ and a participatory share in Christ's own righteousness.

### Phil.3.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1343 δικαιοσύνην, G4100 πίστεως, G2316 θεοῦ

Force. Paul opposes 'my own righteousness from law' (ἐμὴν δικαιοσύνην τὴν ἐκ νόμου, emen dikaiosunen ten ek nomou) to 'the one through faith of Christ, the righteousness from God on the basis of faith' (τὴν διὰ πίστεως Χριστοῦ, τὴν ἐκ θεοῦ δικαιοσύνην ἐπὶ τῇ πίστει, ten dia pisteos Christou, ten ek theou dikaiosunen epi te pistei). The stacked prepositions 'from God' (ἐκ θεοῦ, ek theou), 'through faith' (διὰ πίστεως, dia pisteos), 'on the basis of faith' (ἐπὶ τῇ πίστει, epi te pistei) locate the source of the righteousness in God and exclude the apostle's own performance as its basis. The phrase 'faith of Christ' (πίστεως Χριστοῦ, pisteos Christou) is itself a known genitive ('grammatical form for relationship or source') ambiguity, faith in Christ or the faithfulness of Christ, but either reading keeps the righteousness 'from God' (ἐκ θεοῦ, ek theou).

### Gen.15.6 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H0539 וַיִּשְׁבַּח, H2803 וַיַּחְשְׁבֶהָ לוֹ, H6666 תְּשַׁדָּאָה

Force. Abraham believed ('and he believed', וַיִּשְׁבַּח, he'emin) in 'the Lord' (YHWH, יְהוָה) and he counted it to him ('and he counted it to him', וַיַּחְשְׁבֶהָ לוֹ, vayyachsheveha lo) as righteousness ('righteousness', תְּשַׁדָּאָה, tsedaqah). The verb 'to count, reckon' (חָשַׁב, chashav), attested 124 times in the Old Testament, is glossed count, think, devise, design. In Genesis 15:6 the accounting sense, counted it to him, is in view, the same sense the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint, LXX) captured with 'it was counted' (ἐλογίσθη, elogisthe). This is the source pattern Paul quotes in Romans 4 and Galatians 3 and James cites in James 2:23.

### Ps.32.1 · **for** · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H0835 אָשְׁרֵי, H6588 פֶּשַׁע

Force. Blessed ('blessed', אָשְׁרֵי, ashre) is the one whose transgression ('transgression', פֶּשַׁע, pesha) is forgiven and whose sin is covered. Paul reads this Davidic blessing in Romans 4:7 to 4:8 as the non reckoning of sin that runs parallel to the reckoning of righteousness, so that the same divine accounting both withholds the charge of sin and credits righteousness.

### Jer.23.6 · **for** · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H3068 יְהוָה, H6664 צִדְקָנוּ

Force. The messianic Branch is named 'the Lord our righteousness' (יְהוָה צִדְקָנוּ, YHWH tsidqenu). The noun 'righteousness' (צִדְקָה, tsedeq) carries the first common plural suffix 'our' (נוּ, nu), binding the people's righteousness to the person of the Branch. The people's righteousness is named as residing in another, a prophetic parallel to the New Testament righteousness lodged 'in him' (ἐν αὐτῷ, en auto).

### Isa.53.11 · **for** · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H6663 יַצְדִּיק, H5445 יִסְבֵּל

Force. The Servant will justify ('he will justify', יַצְדִּיק, yatsdiq, the Hebrew causative form, hiphil, meaning 'to cause to do', of 'to be righteous' (צָדִיק, tsadaq), declarative, make or declare righteous) the many, and their iniquities he will bear ('he will bear', יִסְבֵּל, yisbol, from 'to carry a load' (סָבַל, savat)). The Hebrew causative form (hiphil) of 'to be righteous' (צָדִיק, tsadiq) denotes the Servant's declarative justification of others while he simultaneously carries their guilt, the prophetic substrate of the New Testament exchange. The lexicon glosses the verb 'to be righteous' (צָדִיק, tsadaq) as to justify.

### Jas.2.24 · **complicates** · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1344 δικαιοῦται, G2041 ἔργων, G4100 πίστεως

Force. James writes that a person is justified ('is justified', δικαιοῦται, dikaioutai) by works and not by faith alone. At the lexical surface this looks opposed to Paul. The verb 'to justify' (δικαιόω, dikaiōo) carries two attested senses in the canon, to show or prove righteous and to declare or pronounce righteous (lexicon entry on G1344). James 2:23 quotes the same Genesis 15:6 'it was counted' (ἐλογίσθη, elogisthe) formula, so the reckoning verb 'to count or reckon' (λογίζομαι, logizomai) is common ground. The divergence sits in which sense of 'to justify' (δικαιόω, dikaiōo) is operative, demonstrative ('shown to be') for James, declarative ('declared to be') for Paul.

## Cross references invoked

| From      | To        | Source | Votes |
|-----------|-----------|--------|-------|
| Rom.4.3   | Gen.15.6  | tsk    | 1     |
| Rom.4.5   | Rom.4.3   | tsk    | 1     |
| Rom.4.6   | Rom.4.11  | tsk    | 1     |
| Rom.4.7   | Ps.32.1   | tsk    | 1     |
| Rom.4.8   | Isa.53.10 | tsk    | 1     |
| 2Cor.5.21 | Isa.53.4  | tsk    | 1     |
| 2Cor.5.21 | Isa.53.9  | tsk    | 1     |
| Phil.3.9  | Phil.3.6  | tsk    | 1     |
| Jer.23.6  | Jer.33.16 | tsk    | 1     |

## Complicating texts

### Jas.2.24 · addressed

James 2:21 to 2:23 cites the same Genesis 15:6 'it was counted' (ἐλογίσθη, elogisthe) formula that anchors Romans 4. The chronology in Genesis places the reckoning of Genesis 15:6 decades before the offering of Isaac in Genesis 22, so James cannot mean the works produced the reckoning. The lexicon shows 'to justify' (δικαίω, dikaioo) carries both a demonstrative sense, to show to be righteous (Matthew 11:19, Luke 7:35), and a declarative ('a verdict pronounced') forensic ('courtroom-style') sense, to pronounce righteous (Romans 3:24, 3:28, 4:5). James uses the demonstrative sense, the works vindicate the faith already reckoned, while Paul uses the forensic sense. The reckoning verb 'to count or reckon' (λογίζομαι, logizomai) is identical in both, so the two are lexically compatible.

### Jas.2.21 · addressed

Same lexical resolution. James asks whether Abraham was justified by works when he offered Isaac. James 2:23 immediately quotes Genesis 15:6 with the 'it was counted' (ἐλογίσθη, elogisthe) formula, framing the binding of Isaac (Akedah, the Hebrew name for that episode) as the fulfilment of the prior reckoning rather than its ground. The dual sense of 'to justify' (δικαίω, dikaioo), demonstrative ('shown to be') for James and declarative ('declared to be') for Paul, holds the two strands together at the word level.

### Rom.2.13 · addressed

Paul writes that the doers of the law will be justified ('they will be justified', δικαιωθήσονται, dikaiouthesontai). In the immediate flow Romans 2:1 to 3:20, Paul is establishing that no one in fact meets this standard, reaching the universal verdict of Romans 3:19 to 3:20 that no flesh is justified by works of law. The verse states the principle that would justify if anyone could keep it, then Paul shows none can, before introducing the alternative basis in Romans 3:21 to 4:25. The lexical pattern of reckoned righteousness is not disturbed.

### Matt.25.46 · addressed

The judgement of the nations scene appears to make lived works the basis of final acceptance, with 'the righteous' (οἱ δίκαιοι, hoi dikaioi) entering eternal life. The pericope ('the short passage') evaluates obedience as evidence of belonging, and the lexical anchors of the reckoning pattern, 'to count or reckon' (λογίζομαι, logizomai) and 'to justify' (δικαίω, dikaioo) paired with 'the ungodly' (ἄσεβῃ, asebe) and 'apart from works' (χωρὶς ἔργων, choris ergon), are absent here. The Matthean evidential strand and the Pauline forensic ('courtroom-style') strand address different aspects of judgement and do not collide at the word level.

### Rom.5.19 · unaddressed

Although this verse supports the verdict, it carries an unresolved lexical openness worth flagging. The verb 'to constitute or appoint' (καθίστημι, kathistemi) (G2525) is glossed appoint, make, constitute, and in 20 of its 21 canon occurrences it installs someone in an office or role (Matthew 24:45, Luke 12:42, Acts 6:3, Hebrews 5:1, 7:28). Romans 5:19 is its only justification context use. The passive 'they will be constituted' (κατασταθήσονται, katastathesontai) therefore does not, by the word alone, settle whether the many are constituted righteous purely by reckoned status or also by an effected transformation. The verse is consistent with the reckoning pattern but the single verb cannot by itself foreclose the transformative reading, so the openness is recorded rather than papered over.

## Concordance traversed

G3049, G1344, G1343, G1342, G2525, G0765, G4100, G2041, G3107, H2803, H6666, H6664, H6663

## Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

rom4.8-ou-hou at Rom.4.8: impact none. The relative pronoun variation, the marked 'whose' (ὃου, hou) against 'to whom' (ὃν, ho), in the citation of Psalm 32:2 from the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint, LXX) does not alter the verb 'he should reckon' (λογίσσεται, logisetai) or the strong double negation 'in no way' (οὐ μή, ou me). The clause still teaches God's non reckoning of sin under either reading.



2cor5.21-ton-art at 2Cor.5.21: impact none. The marked article 'the' (τὸν, ton) variation at the head of the verse does not change the participial clause 'not having known sin' (μὴ γνόντα ἁμαρτίαν, me gnonta hamartian) or the purpose clause 'so that we might become righteousness of God in him' (ἵνα γενώμεθα δικαιοσύνη θεοῦ ἐν αὐτῷ, hina genometha dikaiousune theou en auto). The exchange logic holds under either reading.

rom10.3-idian at Rom.10.3: impact none. The marked 'their own' (ἰδίαν, idian) reading (their own righteousness) bears on the contrast between God's righteousness and self righteousness but does not touch the cited anchor verses or the reckoning verb. Listed only to confirm the broader chain is variant stable.

All anchor verses are in the Pauline epistles, Genesis, Psalms, Isaiah and Jeremiah, none of which fall in the ingested ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) published window (3 John). The bundle reports not\_in\_ecm\_scope true. SBLGNT (an open Greek New Testament edition), the MorphGNT (a morphology-tagged Greek New Testament) verse text queried from the store, and standard editions agree on the substantive anchors 'to count or reckon' (λογίζομαι, logizomai), 'righteousness' (δικαιοσύνη, dikaiousune), 'to justify' (δικαιῶ, dikaioo), 'ungodly' (ἄσεβής, asebes) and 'to constitute' (καθίστημι, kathistemi) in the cited verses, so the verdict is not variant sensitive.

## Hermeneutics

Primary method. redemptive-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant\_theology, new\_perspective\_on\_paul, participationist\_union\_with\_christ, infused\_transformation\_reading

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

forensic\_imputation\_reading: affirms · Reads 'to count or reckon' (λογίζομαι, logizomai) in Romans 4 as a courtroom and ledger metaphor of crediting. The accounting sense fixed by Romans 4:4 (wage versus grace), the object 'the ungodly' (τὸν ἄσεβῆ, ton asebe) in Romans 4:5, the qualifier 'apart from works' (χωρὶς ἔργων, choris ergon) in Romans 4:6, and the parallel passives of Romans 5:19 are read as a reckoned status assigned to the believer, with the specific content being Christ's own righteousness or obedience credited to the account. On this reading the righteousness is alien (originating outside the believer), not inherent.

faith\_itself\_reckoned\_reading: affirms · Takes the grammar of Romans 4:3 and 4:5 at face value, his faith is reckoned for righteousness, and holds that what God credits is the believer's faith counted as righteousness rather than a transfer of Christ's distinct obedience. This still satisfies the proposition, the righteousness is reckoned and rests on Christ's work received by faith and is not an inherent moral quality, but it locates the reckoned item differently. The text states the act of reckoning plainly but does not spell out whether the thing reckoned is Christ's obedience or the faith itself, so this reading is lexically available.

participationist\_union\_with\_christ: affirms · Emphasises 'in him' (ἐν αὐτῷ, en auto) in 2 Corinthians 5:21 and Philippians 3:9 and the wider 'in Christ' (ἐν Χριστῷ, en Christo) language. The believer becomes God's righteousness by union, sharing in Christ's righteousness rather than receiving an infused (inwardly poured) personal quality. This reading converges with the forensic ('courtroom-style') one on the central claim, the righteousness is not the believer's own inherent property, and it foregrounds the locative ('in-location') phrases the text actually uses.

new\_perspective\_on\_paul: partial · Reads 'to justify' (δικαιῶ, dikaioo) primarily as covenant membership or vindication language and takes works of the law in Romans 3 and 4 to mean ethnic boundary markers rather than meritorious works in general. On this lens Romans 4 chiefly answers who belongs to Abraham's family. Even so, the reckoning of righteousness to the ungodly in Romans 4:5 remains a granted status rather than an inherent one, so the proposition that righteousness is reckoned and not inherent still holds, while the precise meaning of the reckoned righteousness is read covenantally. The dual sense of 'to justify' (δικαιῶ, dikaioo) noted in the lexicon, declare or vindicate, gives this lens its lexical foothold.

infused\_transformation\_reading: denies · Reads the reckoning as God recognising or initiating a real righteousness worked into the believer by grace, drawing on the dominant office installing sense of 'to constitute' (καθίστημι, kathistemi) (constitute, make actually) in Romans 5:19 and on the become language of 'become' (γίνομαι, ginomai) in 2 Corinthians 5:21. On this lens justification names a making righteous, not only a counting righteous. The reading must construe Romans 4:5 (justifies the ungodly) as the inception of an infusion (an inward pouring of righteousness) and must soften 'apart from works' (χωρὶς ἔργων, choris ergon). The accounting force of

'to count or reckon' (λογίζομαι, logizomai), its commercial use in Romans 4:4, and the explicit 'ungodly' (ἀσεβῆ, asebe) object pull against this at the surface, which is why the verdict on the proposition is affirms while this lens is recorded fairly as the dissenting reading.

The verdict turns on the accounting sense of 'to count or reckon' (λογίζομαι, logizomai) plus the 'ungodly' (ἀσεβῆ, asebe) object plus the 'apart from works' (χωρίς ἔργων, choris ergon) qualifier, which together establish that righteousness is reckoned rather than produced from the believer's own state. What the vocabulary does not settle is the content and source of the reckoned righteousness, whether Christ's distinct obedience, the believer's faith counted as righteousness, a participatory share by union, or covenant standing. The redemptive historical method (reading the Bible as one unfolding story climaxing in Christ) is primary because the verdict runs along the Genesis to Isaiah to Pauline arc, with Genesis 15:6 and Isaiah 53:11 as the substrate.

## Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. On what basis does God reckon or declare a person righteous in justification: on the basis of righteousness located in Christ and received by faith, on the basis of the person's faith counted as righteousness, on the basis of righteousness worked inherently into the person, or on some combination?

The stem encodes its own conclusion with the phrases reckoned righteous, Christ's work received by faith, and not on the basis of righteousness inherent in the believer. The neutralized form opens the question to the full range of defensible answers and lets the lexical data adjudicate. The verdict is derived on the original stem and is affirmed because the accounting verb 'to count or reckon' (λογίζομαι, logizomai) (count, reckon), the ungodly object 'the ungodly' (ἀσεβῆ, asebe), the 'apart from works' (χωρίς ἔργων, choris ergon) qualifier and the locative ('in-location') 'in him' (ἐν αὐτῷ, en auto) together support a reckoned and not inherent righteousness. The verdict is unchanged from the prior evidence file.

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## Flags

ecm-shadow · complicating-unresolved